

COMMUNISM

PLAIN SPEAK: (right) CPM General Secretary Prakash Karat with minister M.A. Baby in Kerala



achieved was in the minds of those who had been condemned to servility and exclusion. Gandhian attempts at mitigating hierarchy had consisted of attempts at qualified inclusion within society: lower castes were to be allowed into Hindu temples provided they gave up their older ways of life and worship.

In its creation of a truly regional identity, the Communist movement managed to knit together two crucial historical legacies. The first was the radical, egalitarian and anti-caste message of the great Ezhava intellectual Sri Narayana Guru. Second, it managed to bring together Christians, Hindus and Muslims into a regional politics of development that allowed no space for sectarianism in politics. This was indeed the social revolution that the first Communist state government put the seal on. Two issues which the government had to deal ranged across an entire set of vested interests against the Communists. First, once a new egalitarian imagination had been put in place, the Agrarian Relations Bill, the first comprehensive measure of its kind attempted in India, was introduced. Fixity of tenure for tenants, ceiling on landholdings, protection for the agricultural labourer and agricultural debt relief went alongside minimum wage commit-

tees and securing the "neutralism" of the police. Second, there was an attempt to reform education in the state by regulating the administration of education and introducing new textbooks that reflected a new society. This brought the Church, caste organisations and large landowners together in a formidable lobby which also had the backing of the Centre.

Looking at the history of Kerala since 1957, one may have much to be critical of: a lack of concern for environmental issues, a tradition of political violence, the absence of industry and high rates of unemployment and a very masculine public sphere. The Communist movement, however, succeeded in creating a modern polit-

ical vocabulary centred on issues of hierarchy and subordination in a secular language. There is no contemporary political mileage in summoning up religious divisions in a society with significant minorities of Muslims and Christians. Literacy, equality and a language of rights determine the Malayali imagination. Anand, a Malayali novelist and thinker, encapsulates this in his novel, *Govardhan's Travels*, as he writes a history of injustice and inequality in northern India from the standpoint of a paradoxically universal Malayali egalitarianism.

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E.M.S. NAMBOODIRIPAD, chief minister, 1957

"The police have always been used to suppress mass movements of workers and peasants."